

Electricity Consumer Guide

Friendly, practical answers to common questions about supply, safety, billing and saving energy.

Basics of Electricity Supply and Billing

Q: How does electricity reach my home?

A: Electricity travels from generation plants through transmission lines to substations, is stepped down in voltage, then delivered over distribution lines to your neighborhood and finally through a service line to your meter and home.

Q: What makes up my electricity bill?

A: Typical bills include a fixed charge (connection/availability), energy charge (units used), taxes, and sometimes fuel or power purchase adjustments; items vary by utility and tariff structure.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

1. Fixed (monthly) charge: covers meter, administration and availability.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

2. Energy charge: billed per unit (kWh) consumed during the billing period.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

3. Taxes and surcharges: government taxes, regulatory charges, subsidies adjustments.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

Understanding Electricity Meters and Tariffs

Q: What types of meters will I see?

A: There are electromechanical (older) meters and modern electronic/smart meters that record consumption and may support time-of-day or net metering. Smart meters enable better billing and outage detection.

[pib.gov](https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleaseDetailm.aspx?PRID=1934673)

Q: How do tariffs affect my bill?

A: Tariffs define rates (flat, slab-wise, or time-of-day). Choosing the right tariff or understanding slab thresholds helps manage costs—higher consumption bands typically cost more per unit.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

1. Flat/Uniform tariff: same rate for all units in the period.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

2. Slab/tiered tariff: increasing unit rates as consumption crosses thresholds.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

3. Time-of-day (TOD) tariff: lower rates off-peak, higher during peak hours (often with smart meters).

[pib.gov](https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleaseDetailm.aspx?PRID=1934673)

Rights and Responsibilities of Consumers

Q: What basic rights do I have?

A: Consumers are entitled to accurate, timely bills, clear information on charges, safe and reliable supply, and accessible complaint redressal. Utilities must provide information on connection terms and service standards.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

Q: What are my responsibilities?

A: Pay bills on time, maintain internal wiring safely, allow meter reading/inspection, and follow energy use restrictions during emergencies. Keeping your contact details updated helps the utility reach you with notices.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

1. Right: accurate metering and transparent billing.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

2. Right: timely fault response and safety information.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

3. Responsibility: maintain internal wiring and safety devices.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

4. Responsibility: report outages and unsafe conditions promptly.

[occ.ohio](https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights)

How to Apply for a New Connection

Q: What documents and steps are needed to get a new domestic connection?

A: Apply via your local distribution company (DISCOM) portal or office by submitting identity, address/ownership proof, wiring certificate, and paying application and security charges; track using the application number.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

Example: Register on the DISCOM portal, select 'New Connection', upload Aadhaar and ownership proof, choose load (1–5 kW typical), pay the fee and await site inspection.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

1. Identify DISCOM and register online or visit office.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

2. Fill form: applicant details, premises, load and phase (single/three).

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

3. Upload documents: ID, ownership, wiring certificate, photos.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

4. Pay application and security deposit; note reference number.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

5. Site inspection, meter installation and connection activation.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

Q: What are the essential household electrical safety rules?

A: Keep switches and sockets dry, avoid overloading circuits, use licensed electricians for wiring, and install RCDs (residual current devices) for protection against shocks. Regularly inspect cords and appliances for wear.

[puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips)

Q: How should I use portable generators safely?

A: Operate generators outdoors in well-ventilated areas, never connect directly to household wiring without a transfer switch, and follow fuel handling precautions to avoid carbon monoxide and fire risks.

[puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips)

1. Install RCDs and earthing for critical circuits.

[puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips)

2. Do not run cords under rugs or in wet areas.

[puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips)

3. Hire licensed electricians for major work and obtain wiring certificates.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

4. Use surge protectors for sensitive electronics after outages.

[puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips)

Steps to Report Outages or Faults

Q: Who do I contact when the power goes out?

A: Contact your utility's outage hotline or report via their web/WhatsApp/portal—do not call emergency services for outages; they handle life-safety emergencies. Reporting helps utilities locate and prioritize restoration.

[occ.ohio](<https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights>)

Q: What information should I provide?

A: Provide your name, service address, consumer/account number (if available), description (no power, flicker, sparking), time outage started, and any visible damage or safety hazards.

[occ.ohio](<https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights>)

1. Check neighbors to confirm if outage is local.

[occ.ohio](<https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights>)

2. Call your DISCOM outage number or use their portal with account/reference.

[occ.ohio](<https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights>)

3. Report hazards (live wires, sparking poles) and keep distance.

[puc.pa](<https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips>)

4. Follow official restoration updates; power may be restored in phases.

[occ.ohio](<https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights>)

Energy-Saving Practices — Everyday Tips

Q: Which simple steps save the most electricity?

A: Use efficient lighting (LEDs), set ACs to a moderate temperature, insulate and seal homes, and run appliances (dishwasher, washer) with full loads on off-peak times for lower bills. Small daily habits compound into large savings.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

Example: Replacing five 60 W incandescent bulbs with 9 W LEDs can cut lighting energy by over 80% for the same useful light.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

1. Switch to LED lighting and smart controls.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

2. Use energy-efficient appliances and check star ratings.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

3. Shift heavy loads to off-peak hours if on TOD tariff.

[pib.gov](https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetailm.aspx?PRID=1934673)

4. Unplug idle chargers and use power strips to cut phantom loads.

[kimbal](https://kimbal.io/blog/how-much-does-1-unit-of-electricity-cost-in-india/)

FAQ — Billing and Disputes

Q: I found a billing error—what now?

A: Contact your utility's billing/customer care with details, request an explanation, and use formal complaint channels if unresolved; keep meter readings and payment receipts as evidence.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

Q: Why did my bill jump suddenly?

A: Sudden increases can result from seasonal loads (ACs), rate changes, billing adjustments, estimated readings being corrected, or a faulty meter—ask the utility for a meter check if you suspect an error.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

1. Record and compare meter readings each billing cycle.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

2. If billed estimate, request an actual reading or meter check.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

3. Escalate via consumer grievance redressal if not resolved.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

FAQ — Meters, Net Metering and Smart Features

Q: Can I install rooftop solar and get credited?

A: Many utilities permit rooftop solar with net metering/net-billing; you must apply, install approved meters, and follow interconnection rules to receive credits for exported energy.

[thc.nic]

([https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20\(Rights%20of%20Consumers\)%20Rules,%202020.pdf](https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20(Rights%20of%20Consumers)%20Rules,%202020.pdf))

Q: How do smart meters help me?

A: Smart meters provide accurate readings, support TOD tariffs, detect outages faster and enable consumption tracking so you can adjust behavior and spot unusual usage.

[pib.gov](<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetailm.aspx?PRID=1934673>)

1. Net metering: export excess energy and receive credit per local rules.

[thc.nic]

([https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20\(Rights%20of%20Consumers\)%20Rules,%202020.pdf](https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20(Rights%20of%20Consumers)%20Rules,%202020.pdf))

2. Smart meters: better data, potential for dynamic pricing and quicker fault detection.

[pib.gov](<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetailm.aspx?PRID=1934673>)

3. Ask your DISCOM about rules and incentives before installing generation.

[thc.nic]

([https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20\(Rights%20of%20Consumers\)%20Rules,%202020.pdf](https://thc.nic.in/Central%20Governmental%20Rules/Electricity%20(Rights%20of%20Consumers)%20Rules,%202020.pdf))

Practical Example — Applying for a Connection (Step-by-step)

Q: Can you walk me through a typical online application?

A: Yes—register on the DISCOM portal, choose 'New Connection', fill applicant and premise details, select load and phase, upload documents, pay fees, and track the inspection and meter installation via your reference number.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

1. Register with mobile/email and verify OTP.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

2. Submit ID/ownership proof and wiring certificate from a licensed electrician.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)

3. Pay application fee and security deposit online; save receipt.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

4. Attend site inspection and clear any wiring issues; get meter installed.

[citizennest](https://www.citizennest.com/guide/new-electricity-connection-apply)

Emergency Guidance and Restoration Expectations

Q: What should I do during long outages?

A: Keep fridge/freezer doors closed to preserve food, use battery lamps instead of candles, switch off non-essential appliances, and follow the utility's restoration bulletins; do not approach fallen wires and report hazards immediately.

[mass](https://www.mass.gov/info-details/power-outage-safety-tips)

Q: How long will restoration take?

A: Restoration times vary with cause and severity—utilities often prioritize critical services (hospitals, water pumping) first, then neighborhoods; check official channels for staged restoration updates.

[occ.ohio](https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights)

- Preserve supplies and follow safety advice. [puc.pa](https://www.puc.pa.gov/press-release/2022/puc-offers-winter-storm-utility-safety-tips) - Use official utility channels for status and support. [occ.ohio](https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights) - If you rely on medical equipment, register with your utility for priority or seek alternative power plans. [occ.ohio](https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights)

Useful Contacts and Next Steps

Q: Where can I get more help or escalate complaints?

A: Start with your DISCOM's customer care, use their website/portal for formal complaints, and consult your regional electricity regulatory commission or consumer forum if unresolved. Keep records of all communications and receipts.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

Example contacts: DISCOM outage hotline, billing support email, regional regulator consumer cell—find local numbers on your utility bill or website.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

1. DISCOM customer care and outage hotlines — primary contact.

[occ.ohio](https://www.occ.ohio.gov/factsheet/power-outage-tips-and-customer-rights)

2. Escalate to consumer grievance redressal officer if needed.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

3. Approach the regulator or consumer court for unresolved disputes.

[apserc.nic](https://apserc.nic.in/pdf/Citizen's_Charter.pdf)

Thank you for reading the Electricity Consumer Guide — follow safety rules, save energy, and report issues promptly to keep your community powered and safe.

Notes: - Billing, rights and application steps reference typical DISCOM and regulatory guidance for consumers. [citizennest]
(https://www.citizennest.com/guide/electricity-new-connection-apply)